



make each day feel new again

daybreak

the prompt



a **new** way to sense the world

the challenge

“Design a tool that tracks, measures, visualizes or quantifies an aspect of human sensory experience. Within the tool, provide the ability to detect, enhance, or manipulate those same sensory inputs.”

our approach

We explored an often-overlooked sense: **the ability to perceive novelty in everyday life.**

Over time, familiar environments become predictable, which causes people to overlook subtle changes around them.

Daybreak introduces a new perceptual layer that helps users notice small environmental shifts and opportunities to keep familiar spaces feeling fresh and exciting.

the problem + target users

when days become dull

For many students and workers, life follows a familiar rhythm: wake, commute, work, repeat.

Commuting the same routes, visiting the same places, and following the same schedules can lead to **sensory desensitization**. Environments that were once engaging begin to feel predictable and routine.

Over time, we slip into autopilot, overlooking small changes and moments of curiosity. When novelty fades, **everyday life can start to feel monotonous and disconnected**.

who experiences this?

This pattern is especially common among people with structured routines, such as:

- **College students** navigating the same campus paths daily
- **Office workers** commuting on fixed schedules



why this matters

significance of novelty in everyday experiences

novelty...



1. boosts **creativity** & stimulates divergent thinking
2. strengthens **memory** by increasing neuroplasticity
3. increases **happiness** by creating a sense of curiosity & adventure

source: <https://houstondbtcenter.com/magic-of-novelty/>

“Exposure to unfamiliar stimuli and environments are also linked to a **decrease in stress, anxiety, and depression.**”

source: <https://seattleanxiety.com/psychiatrist/2022/7/21/novelty>



user survey insights

breaking the routine

To understand how routine affects everyday perception, we surveyed 16 students about their daily experiences with repetition and monotony.

63%

agreed that repetitive routines make them feel more disengaged or disconnected from their surroundings

94%

said they feel their days “blur together” at least occasionally

open-ended responses:

“Life feels kinda monotonous and **I need to do things to break the routines and feel more alive**”

“I literally am **in a loop** of waking up early and going to class and then studying every single day... everything **doesn't feel real**”

“I feel like I'm on **autopilot.**”



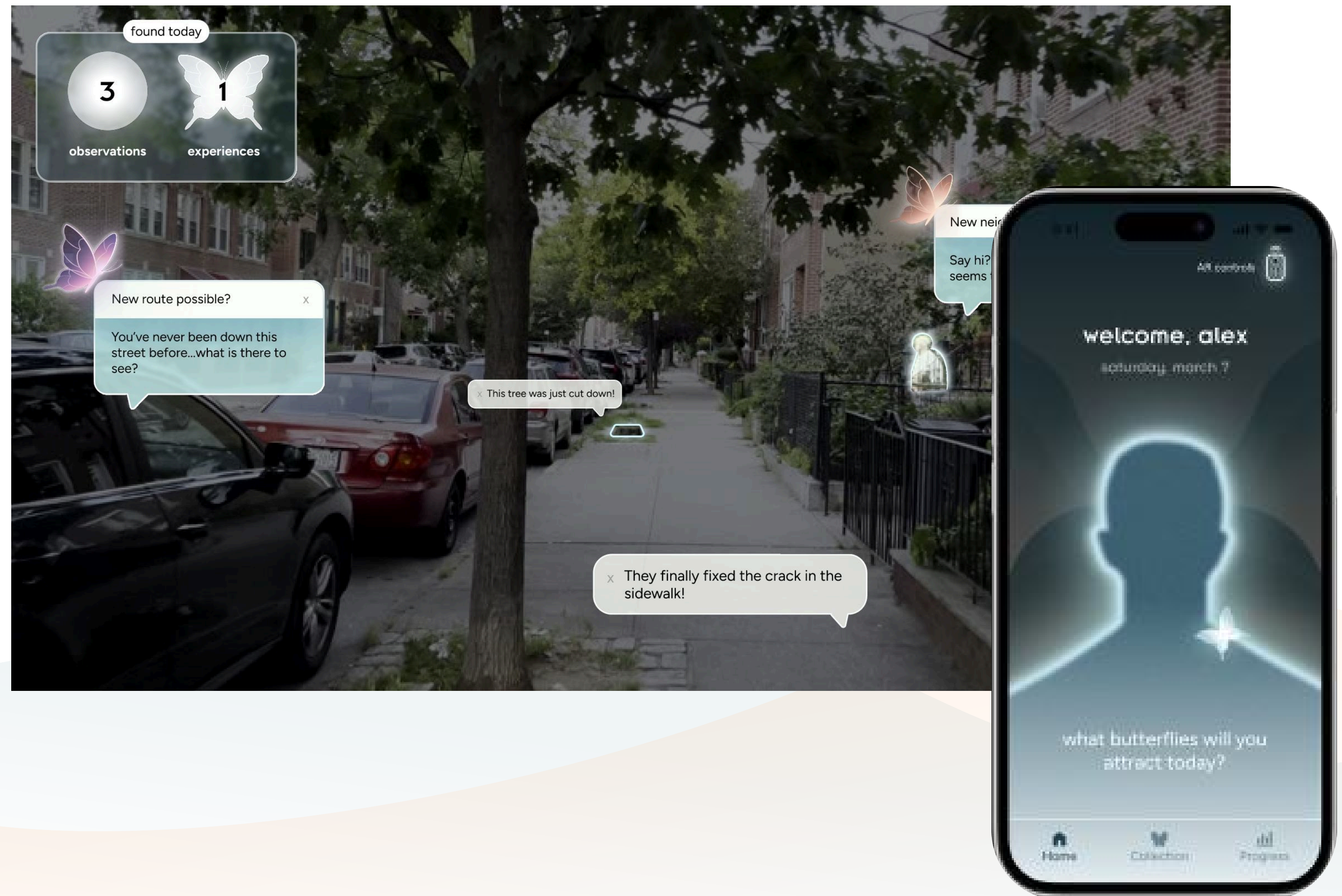
design opportunity

If everyday environments feel too predictable,
how might we help people sense moments of
novelty in their routines?

our solution

daybreak

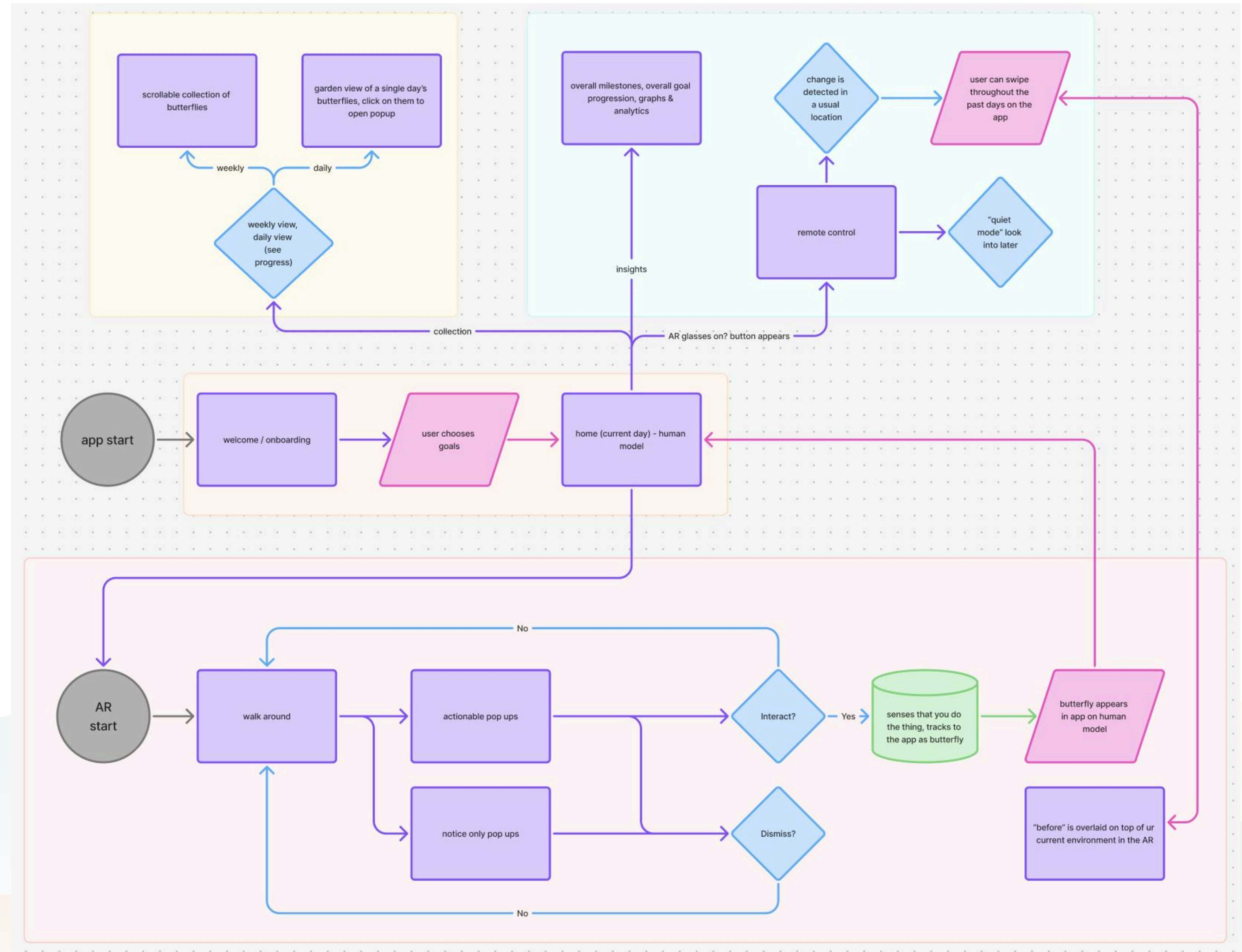
Daybreak is a speculative AR + companion app that helps users rediscover novelty in everyday environments





user flow system interactions

We mapped how users navigate between the AR interface and the companion mobile app, as well as how observations and experiences are captured and reflected across both platforms.



how daybreak works

augmented reality interface

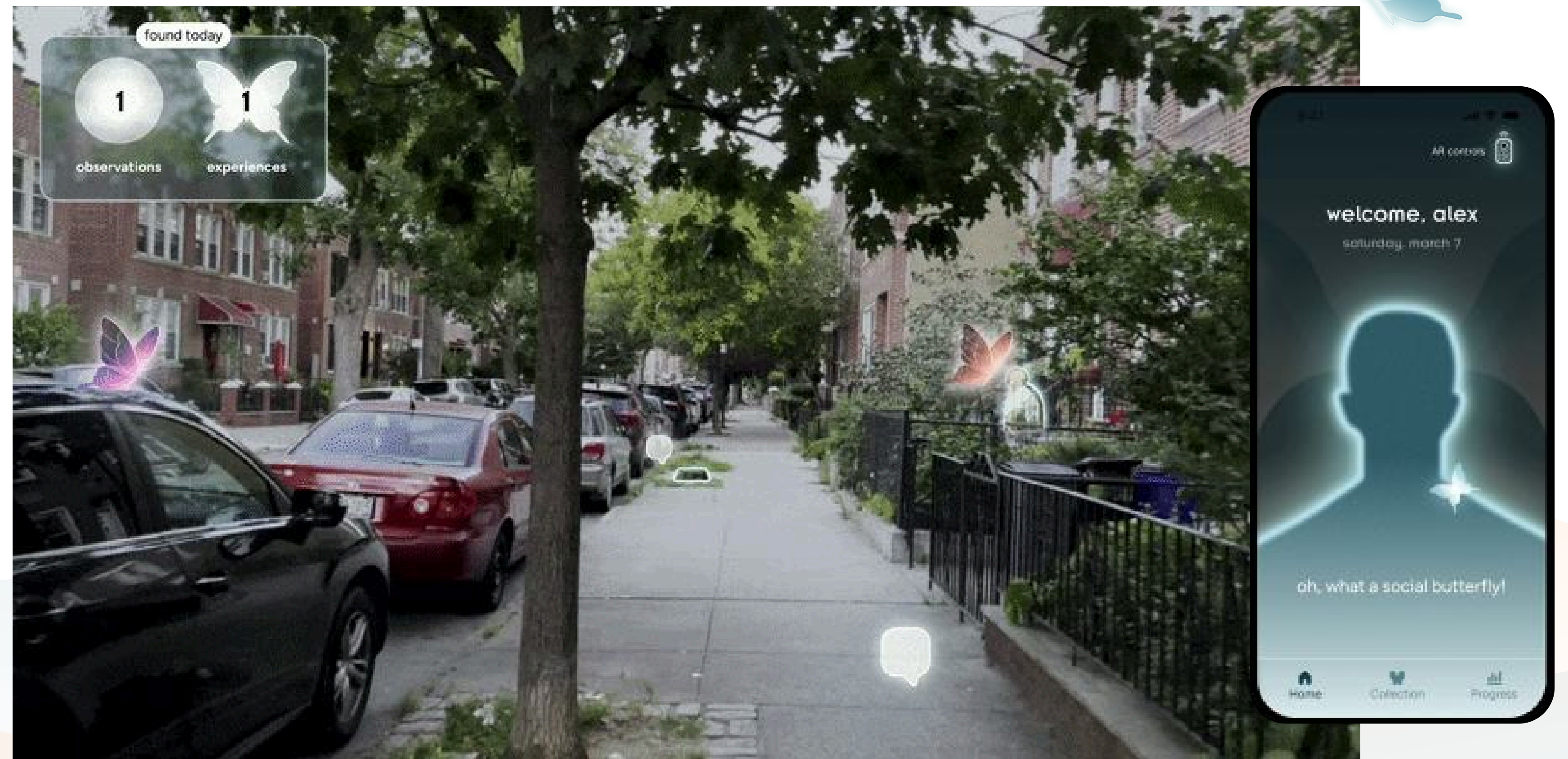
Senses new changes in the environment. For example:

- a new café item
- a new chalk drawing
- a new bird's nest

Some discoveries include **butterfly prompts** encouraging, but not forcing, interaction & exploration

- a new route to take
- a new neighbor to meet
- a new hobby to try

These butterflies are then collected.



how daybreak works

tracking progress

The app tracks and visualizes collected butterflies, “bucket list” goals, and a “wonder meter” of how different each day is

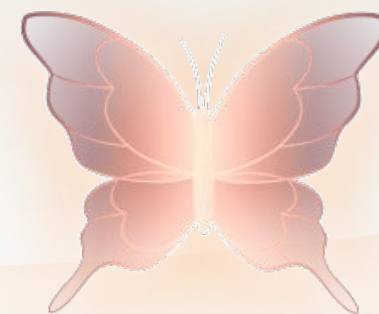
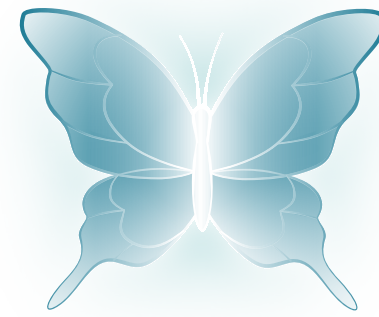
Users can reflect on their experiences and see how their world changes



our solution

try our full prototype!

theming & visual design direction



butterflies

We chose butterflies to represent the new interactions due to their symbolism for souls, rebirth, and transformation in many cultures. They guide the user to personal rebirth - the restoration of novelty

3 main use cases

making the routine feel different

User walks the same route to campus every day, and he feels like he's stuck in a monotonous loop.

Daybreak helps him sense the small details and changes in the world around him, as well as encourage himself to try new things, take new steps.



goal tracking and progression

During onboarding, user chooses what kinds of novelty she wants more of in her life, such as social interactions or new hobbies.

Daybreak tracks these interactions over time and visualizes progress, helping users see how they're gradually expanding their daily experiences.

view changes in familiar locations over time

In AR mode, users can select or scrub through dates to see how a familiar place has changed over time.

Daybreak overlays past moments and subtle differences—like decorations, plants growing, or murals appearing—revealing how environments evolve even when routines stay the same.



edge case: quiet mode

designing for sensory overstimulation

62% of survey participants are prone to overstimulation from unexpected change (e.g. bright lights, loud sounds, crowded environments) - how can we better control **which** changes we sense?

"Quiet mode" in AR view reduces sensory input. Visually noisy areas are desaturated, environmental sounds are muffled, and non-essential pop-ups are hidden.

This allows users to stay aware of their surroundings while experiencing a less overwhelming environment.



To keep the interface lightweight, actionable butterfly prompts are collapsed by default and only expand when the user looks in their direction.

Users can also customize which pop-ups appear and limit how many are shown at once through the app.



potential impact

ways we could measure success

observational awareness

If users log **3–5 butterfly interactions daily**, this will lead to **increased attention to their surroundings**



exploration of routine spaces

Butterflies track how often users **engage with exploration or activity prompts** which demonstrate **a shift away from autopilot routines**

positive daily reflection

Weekly insights in the app help **users reflect on the variety of their experiences** across places, activities, and social moments.

reduced routine fatigue

Survey-based follow-ups could measure whether users report **less monotony or more curiosity** in daily life over time

future opportunities

cocoons (save for later)

Users may not always have time to complete a butterfly task right away (e.g., a local pottery class that just opened). They could save it for later as a cocoon, which later transforms into a butterfly once completed

location heatmap

A map that visualizes where users frequently go vs. rarely visit to encourage exploration outside their usual routines

friends system

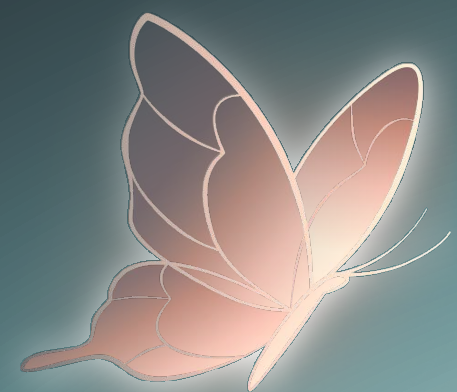
Sharing discoveries with friends can inspire new ideas and encourage users to expand their sense of novelty together



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